Sukkos · Zman Simchaseinu • Diburim

From Shaveh to Sho'eva

The Water That Makes Us One

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Sukkah · Arba Minim · Nisuch HaMayim · Achdus

I. Zman Simchaseinu

We are about to go into Sukkos, and Sukkos is phenomenal. More than any other chag, it is zman simchaseinu, the time of our joy. It is the chag we attribute entirely to simcha.

זְמַן שִׂמְחָתֵנוּ

"The time of our rejoicing." — from the Yom Tov tefillos

In Yaaleh V'Yavo and throughout our tefillos, each chag carries its own name. Pesach is zman cheiruseinu, the time of our freedom, when we speak of coming out of Mitzrayim. Shavuos is zman matan Toraseinu, the time of the giving of the Torah. But Sukkos is joy itself.

Each chag also carries its own defining avodah. On Shavuos we sit and learn Torah. Someone might jokingly call eating cheesecake a mitzvah, but the reality of the day is Torah. On Pesach we have the arba kosos, and above all v'higadta l'vincha, telling over the story through the Haggadah. On Rosh Hashanah it is the shofar. On Yom Kippur, teshuvah. But Sukkos has more than one. Two and a half, we might say. Really there are three avodos worth looking at closely.

II. Three Avodos, and the Shape of an Embrace

First is the sukkah itself:

בַּסֻּכֹּת תֵּשְׁבוּ שִׁבְעַת יָמִים

"You shall dwell in sukkos for seven days." — Vayikra 23:42

Bound up with the mitzvah is the command to remember why we were given it. There is a machlokes in the Gemara whether the sukkos of the Midbar were actual huts, sukkos mamash, or whether we are remembering the Ananei HaKavod, the Clouds of Glory.[1] And then there are all the halachos of what a sukkah actually is.

Second is the mitzvah of arba minim, taking four different species and holding them together. Chazal teach that these four correspond to four kinds of Jews. The esrog has both taste and fragrance, like the Jew who has both Torah and good deeds. The lulav, the branch of the date palm, has taste but no fragrance, like the one who has Torah but not good deeds. The hadas has fragrance but no taste, like the one who has good deeds but not Torah. And the aravah has neither, like the Jew who has neither to his credit. We take all four and bind them together as one.

There is a beautiful connection between these first two mitzvos through the idea of a hug. A hug is one of the deepest expressions of love. With the arba minim we take all four and hold them together, drawing them close to us. The sukkah carries the same idea. A sukkah can stand with four walls, with three, or even with two full walls and part of a third. The Ari Z"L connects the very structure of the sukkah to the image of an embrace. To sit in a sukkah is to be surrounded, held, hugged.

And then there is a third avodah, one that stands apart from the others: nisuch hamayim, the pouring of water upon the mizbeach, together with the Simchas Beis HaSho'eva.

III. Why Water?

The Mishnah makes an astonishing statement about this celebration:

מִי שֶׁלֹּא רָאָה שִׂמְחַת בֵּית הַשּׁוֹאֵבָה לֹא רָאָה שִׂמְחָה מִיָּמָיו

"Whoever never saw the celebration of the Simchas Beis HaSho'eva never saw true simcha in all his days." — Sukkah 51a

That is a powerful, sweeping claim. And what was actually happening there? Sho'eva means drawing. They would draw water from the Shiloach, bring it to the Beis HaMikdash, and pour it upon the mizbeach.

[1]Sukkah 11b, the machlokes of R' Eliezer and R' Akiva.

When we picture the avodah of the mizbeach, water is not what comes to mind. We think of yayin and dam. We think of korbanos. We think of the ketores. We think of the minchah, and even flour mixed with oil at least feels substantial. The very idea of a libation carries enormous weight. With wine, that weight is so great that entire areas of halacha surround it, and non-mevushal wine holds a different halachic status precisely because wine is fit to be poured, even in avodah zarah. But water? When we imagine the service of the Beis HaMikdash as a whole, we do not imagine water. And yet here, water becomes the center of the greatest joy of the year.

IV. From the Yamim Noraim Into the Hut

Mah hakesher? What is the connection? We come to Sukkos straight out of Yom Kippur, that awesome day when we hold ourselves back from everything physical and reach for tremendous spiritual heights. On Rosh Hashanah the entire world is judged, and we have spoken about the connection to Nitzavim, where all of us stand together as one. On Yom Kippur we spoke about teshuvah, about how a din may sometimes need to come down, and yet how a person can take responsibility and lift some of it for someone who simply cannot carry it themselves.

And then, immediately, we go outside. Even on Yom Kippur we sleep indoors, in a bed. We do not deliberately expose ourselves to the elements. Now, suddenly, we leave the comfort of our homes and step out into a hut. There has to be a larger message here than remembering that we once dwelled in huts, taking some things that grow from the ground, and having a good time.

V. The Leveling of the Playing Field

So let us look at what these mitzvos share. Sukkos is an astonishing leveling of the playing field.

Baruch Hashem, I work in high tech and have a good parnasah. It is comfortable. And yet I cannot afford to own a home right now. I would like to, but I am renting. I have friends with larger families living in smaller apartments, and I know people with beautiful, massive apartments that do not have a single balcony kosher for a sukkah.

The status quo of life, what my wife would call the constant keeping up with the Joneses, begins to fall away the moment we look at the sukkah. A sukkah has its walls and its minimum requirements. Above us, we are not comparing shingles or roof tiles or solar panels. We have simple sticks, branches, and leaves, things no longer attached to the ground, no longer growing. Shaveh. Equal. We all have the same mitzvah, and we are all sitting inside the same kind of hut.

And there is more. People who live in glass houses should not throw stones, and when you are living outdoors in your sukkah, you can hear your neighbors, because they are outdoors in their sukkah too. Sometimes you can see into other people's sukkos, on sidewalks, in parking lots, on balconies. Some of what we normally keep hidden gets stripped away, and in that exposure there is a strange and beautiful equality.

VI. Arba Minim and Water, the Great Equalizers

The arba minim carry this same message. As we saw, the four species run from the Jew with both taste and fragrance to the one with neither, and yet all of them are bound together, b'yachad. Missing even a single one leaves the set incomplete.

Here too the playing field is level. You can buy the most magnificent esrog and a towering lulav, or a perfectly kosher esrog closer to the size of a lemon and an ordinary lulav. There is a minimum shiur, and there are halachos, but the mitzvah is the same. And honestly, even when you walk over and look closely at someone else's set, you often cannot tell the difference the way you can between a flashy car and a plain one, or a designer suit and something off the rack at Marks & Spencer. For the record, I happen to love Marks & Spencer, and no, this is not a paid advertisement. Yes, we have different minhagim, an esrog from Eretz Yisrael, a Yanover esrog from Italy, but the equality remains.

And now we come back to the water. What is nisuch hamayim? It is water, drawn and brought to the mizbeach. We do not ask whether it was imported, or whether it came in a glass bottle or a plastic one. Water is perhaps the most basic element of life. Our bodies are mostly water. The planet is mostly water. We daven for rain and for dew. Water is one of the most basic requirements of existence, and it is an incredible equalizer. We all need it. We draw it, and we can draw it together.

VII. Shaveh Becomes Sho'eva

These three, the sukkah, the arba minim, and the water, bind us together the very way we bind the arba minim themselves. They strip away the flashy externals and give us the ability to look at our neighbor and say: we are the same. Different, but the same. The same in that we are Yidden. The world at large is doing its best right now to remind us of that, and we do not need them to remind us, because we can look at one another and remember it ourselves.

And there is a remez hidden inside the very name of the celebration. Simchas Beis HaSho'eva.

שׁוֹאֵבָה

Look at its letters: shin, vav, aleph, beis, hey. There is another word strikingly close to it, shaveh, meaning equal:

שָׁוֶה

Shin, vav, hey. Shaveh means equal. I am equal to you, and you are equal to the next person. Maybe I am an esrog with a beautiful pitom. Or halevai, maybe I am a beinoni, a little lumpy, a little green, without a pitom. Maybe I am a hadas with its perfect sets of three, or maybe one of my leaves is a little crooked, a little long, a little short. Maybe I am the lulav, or the aravah. We are different. But shaveh.

Now look again at sho'eva. Beyond the letters of shaveh, two more have entered: aleph and beis. Av. Father. We have just spent a week and a half calling out Avinu Malkeinu. Hashem is our Father. When we become shaveh, when we recognize the equality between us and live together b'yachad, then shaveh becomes sho'eva, because av, our Father, has entered into it.

VIII. Water That Embraces

So we can all dwell in the sukkah. We can all hold the arba minim, whether a whole community once shared a single set, or one person buys the most beautiful set and lends

it to another al tenai that it be returned afterward. We can all be yotzei. There is shaveh. And when that shaveh is realized properly, we arrive at the avodah of nisuch hamayim, which Chazal teach is halacha l'Moshe miSinai. And Yeshayahu reminds us:

וּשְׁאַבְתֶּם מַיִם בְּשָׂשׂוֹן מִמַּעַיְנֵי הַיְשׁוּעָה

"You shall draw water with joy from the wellsprings of salvation." — Yeshayahu 12:3

The sho'eva, the drawing, is done with joy. And where does the yeshuah, the salvation, come from? From our Av, from Hashem. When we are unified together, we are being unified with Him.

When we are wrapped and enclosed and engulfed by the sukkah, we have an image of all of Klal Yisrael together. Chazal teach that kol Yisrael re'uyim leisheiv b'sukkah achas (Sukkah 27b), that all of Israel is fit to sit in a single sukkah. United, all the different types and flavors of Jews, like the arba minim, and we do it together. Tahor. Pure. With water. With our Av.

Water is inside of us. Water covers so much of the world around us. Water is a gift. Think of Eliyahu HaNavi and the drought, and then the gift of water that came afterward. Without water we dry up. Without water there is no food. Without water everything grows dirty. With water we become naki, clean.

There is something here of the mikvah as well, something we will return to in a few weeks as we finish the Torah, come back to Bereishis, and move forward into Noach. Water can surround us in a healthy way. We can be embraced by water, rather than meet it the way it came in the days of Noach.

So as we enter this Shabbos and this Sukkos, we are given a brachah. We get to be enveloped and hugged by Hashem in the sukkah, and we get to bring together, and in a sense to hug together, all the different minim, all the different kinds of Jews. We begin with shaveh, and through shaveh we come to sho'eva, drawing our Father into that very equality.

חַג שָׂמֵחַ

Good Shabbos · Good Yom Tov

Reflection Questions

- *The sukkah strips away the constant keeping up with the Joneses. What is one external marker of status that I hold onto, which Sukkos is inviting me to set down this year?*
- *When I look at a fellow Jew whose life looks nothing like mine, can I honestly say we are the same? Where do I still struggle to see that shaveh?*
- *The sukkah and the arba minim are both a form of embrace. Do I allow myself to feel held by Hashem, or do I keep even Him at arm's length?*
- *We bind all four minim together, including the one with neither taste nor smell. Whom in my life am I leaving out of the set, and what would it take to hold them close?*
- *Shaveh becomes sho'eva only when av, our Father, enters into it. Where can I bring the awareness of Hashem as my Father into a relationship that right now feels merely equal, or merely transactional?*
- *Yeshayahu speaks of drawing water with joy from the wellsprings of salvation. What is the wellspring I can draw from this Sukkos, and how can I draw it together with others rather than alone?*